

My Rap Against Rap

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I'll never forget the first time I went with some buddies in the early '70s to see "The Godfather." I don't know how many violent films I'd seen before that one, but for me "The Godfather" was the serious joint. Gangsters, guns and violence have always held a fascination among Americans, and blacks like me are no different. I was mesmerized by "The Godfather," mainly because its machine gun shootouts and retaliatory murders among competing "families" took the thrill of gang warfare to another level.

I was most impressed by the ruthless code of principles that governed the gangsters' lives. They had a way of resolving conflict that was appealing to a teenager trying to work through the murky rites of manhood. The message I picked up was, if somebody double-crosses you, he deserves to die. I remember sitting in the theater and thinking, Yeah, that's right. He deserves to die.

After "The Godfather" ended, I concluded that was the hippest flick I'd ever seen. My buddies and I stepped outdoors, inspired and hyped, so hyped that we bopped down the sidewalk talking loud and intentionally bumping into people, hoping somebody would protest and give us an excuse to do a bare-knuckled version of what we'd just seen on the movie screen. Clearly, we were young and impressionable and less able to filter fantasy from fact. "The Godfather" was fantasy, but to us – a bunch of spirited boys trying to define ourselves and identify with a group – it was a celebration of machismo, a celebration that elevated the glory and glamor of gang life.

I eventually got my chance to do the Godfather thing when an older guy in the neighborhood threatened my girl. Because that dude had offended my lady and, by extension, disrespected me, I concluded: He deserves to die.

I was 19, and it didn't take much more than that emotion, at that age, to push me into reckless action. When I ran into that guy, I gunned him down. From the moment I pulled the trigger, it was like one great fantasy, as glorious as the gangland slayings in that movie I'd seen. After he collapsed, I stood over him, proud that I'd properly dispensed street justice and upheld the code of Godfather principles that I'd embraced. Later that night, I wound up sitting in a police station, being fingerprinted and booked. That's when fantasy faded. That's when the real me resurfaced. That's when I shed my pseudo-gangster persona and discovered what I really was: a silly, scared teenager who was mixed up in the head.

Lucky for me, the guy lived. I went to court and got off with a light sentence.

But I never stopped thinking about the shooting and the influences that had led me to do such things. I thought about it again recently while following reports of efforts by Attorney General Janet Reno and others to press for restrictions on TV and movie violence. Their efforts are a reminder of a child-rearing truism that seems to have been lost on too many of us: Young people bombarded with images of sex and violence often find it hard to separate fantasy from fact. And some can't resist the temptation to act out what they've seen.

With public support swelling for voluntary or mandatory control, it's probably inevitable that concrete steps will be taken. That's encouraging, but there is something about the campaign that's unsettling to me: If Reno and others succeed, it will ensure that white kids get less exposure to graphic images that may influence them; but any controls may overlook a

volatile area that's specific to blacks. The truth is, white kids are more plugged into TV, and black kids nowadays are more into music, especially rap.

Of course, not all rap is bad; in fact much of it is so brilliant that it makes me shout. But more and more, the good stuff is being overshadowed by a torrent of obscene lyrics and graphic videos.

Especially troubling are the lyrics in "gangsta rap," which became the dominant strain in the late 1980s. It often denigrates women and glorifies guns and gangs. Consider this catchy piece of advice from popular rapper Dr. Dre and imagine how it sounds to a young boy's ears:

Rat-a-tat and a tat like that
 Never hesitate to put a nigga on his back ...

Plain and simple, that is a boastful call for black men to kill each other. Lyrics like these have become so pervasive that they're the accepted norm.

On its face, it may seem crazy for someone to tie music to behavior. But the history of African Americans shows that, from the days of slavery to the present, music has always played a monumental role in what we think and do. It has always been an agent of change.

Anyone who really understands the nature of rap knows that it's more than mere rhyming words. It's a phenomenon, the central part of an unorganized but powerful cultural movement – hip hop – that influences the way young blacks walk, talk, dress and think.

The key element is aggression – in rappers' body language, tone and witty rhymes – that often leaves listeners hyped, on edge, angry about ... something.

Perhaps the most important element in gangsta rap is its messages, which center largely around these ideas: that women are no more than "bitches and hos," disposable playthings who exist merely for men's abusive delight; that it's cool to use any means necessary to get the material things you want; and most importantly, it's admirable to be cold-blooded and hard. Check out this rap by Just-Ice, showing us an aspect of hip-hop that ain't so hip:

Don't try to get too close
 And try to kiss me and hug me
 Start to caress me, then say you love me.
 'Cause I don't feel shit
 It's only rhythm that I ride
 The only love I got is psychopathic homicide ...

When rap music first surfaced, many blacks – including me – overlooked the harsh lyrics because they were viewed as gritty urban political expression – outrage at a hostile white world. Then, over time, the language changed. Rappers who once sang about being oppressed began sounding oppressive and hateful themselves. Again, Just-Ice:

Faggots, bitches,
 Look how their ass switches,
 They see Just-Ice come
 and they move before they get stitches
 Persistent, insistent
 nothing changes, nothing different
 A bullet or a bat,
 Just pick it ...

Gangsta rappers often defend their themes by saying they reflect a reality that they're not responsible for. The rappers' justification would be more persuasive if the brutality they toast had always been part of our reality. But this is more a case of life imitating art in the worst of ways.

90 Apparently, many rappers believe their own hype, and some don't hesitate to act on what they sing about. Look at: Tupac Shakur, arrested in Atlanta earlier this month for shooting two cops. Flavor Flav, shooting at a guy he suspected of having sex with his girlfriend. Snoop Doggy Dogg, charged in connection with a murder, who says he packed two guns as "a protection thang."

95 Other rappers have faced charges for rape, shootings and assorted other crimes. I can't condemn them for getting into trouble, because I've been there myself. But I keep worrying about those kids who can't tell the difference between music and reality, and how this may affect them.

"It's not rap itself, it's the messages that some of the popular rap generates," says William 100 Byrd, a clinical psychologist who works with black children in Washington. "When you bombard someone with those messages, it causes conflict, even within those who may have been taught other values. With the messages, not only are they being bombarded with radio, they get video. So it's what you hear and what you see."

Obviously, gangsta rap does not inspire every young listener to pick up a gun, but what, I 105 wonder, is the impact of all this on people already at risk?

"While the vast majority of kids are able to take negative rap and put it in perspective, some of our most vulnerable ones are influenced," says Melvin Williams, interim commissioner for the D.C. Commission on Mental Health Services. "Those young people who have faulty parenting or no parenting at all are particularly vulnerable to influences such as rap."

110 When it comes to the violence around us, it's undoubtedly true that other complex social factors – public apathy, parental neglect, the allure of drugs and guns – are also to blame. And even the most hard-edged gangsta rap, when isolated from those factors, is probably harmless.

But given all the other forces messing with black folks' minds, negative lyrics are an addition 115 that we just don't need.

Many have been reluctant to speak out against such material because they aren't convinced of its influence. Or, they say, there's nothing new – music has always had its share of violent themes. Furthermore, they say, there's no empirical proof, no hard data that shows a direct relation between, say, gangsta rap and drive-by shootings.

120 What they leave out is that never before have young people been bombarded non-stop by such violent language and imagery. The fact is that, more than anything else – their mamas, their daddys, their preachers and teachers – the minds of many young blacks seem to be homed in on rap, to the tune of \$700 million annually.

Social scientists say that while they can't measure the degree to which constant exposure to 125 violent images in music and on TV affect young people, they're sure that it has some impact. Na'im Akbar, a psychologist who often writes and lectures about such matters, acknowledges that the effect of negative messages on young people is not something that can be quantified. Yet he contends, "You can't prove that it's causative, but it certainly is correlational."

Here are some correlations that I've been mulling over: Black-on-black violence – especially 130 in juvenile violence – has escalated sharply only since the late 1980s, when the popularity of gangsta rap was on the rise. In Washington in a three-year period (1988-90), the number of juvenile homicide arrests almost tripled (from 26 to 67). Those numbers correspond with nationwide statistics, which suggest that the number of juvenile killings has almost doubled in the last 10 years and that the rate of juvenile violent crime has risen by more than 40 per-

135 cent. Even if you make the argument that black-on-black drug wars account for many of the murders, and even if you concede that there are a lot more guns on the street – a condition of the crack economy – that still doesn't wholly explain the sharp rise in random violence. The sudden, unexplained change in the values and behavior of young blacks in rural American towns is another development that has only taken place in recent years. Earlier genera-

140 tions, who were cut off geographically from violent urban influences, now have ready access
 to hip-hop music and videos. Now we've begun hearing more about random violence in
 places such as Kansas and North Carolina, where a few murders a year were once big news.
 What all this means to me is that while we've been searching for complex sociological expla-
 145 quite simple, something dangling right under our collective noses – and ears.
 It's not hard to imagine that young blacks look to rappers – many of whom are only kids
 themselves – as people they want to emulate. Hero-worship and fantasy is a big part of young
 people's lives. Basketball legend Michael Jordan is paid millions to endorse sneakers because
 150 "be like Mike." By the time Jordan reached the height of his fame, young black men all over
 America were fantasizing – shaving their heads, wearing black sneakers and even trying to
 walk pigeon-toed, just like him.
 Nobody fantasizes more than young black men. When you live in a world that limits your
 hopes, reality is often too much to bear. Because they are largely invisible, black males fanta-
 155 size about becoming professional athletes – stations they think will make the world acknowl-
 edge them. Because they are powerless, they are consumed with the symbols of power – guns
 and gangstas.
 They imagine themselves as godfathers and, sadly, some actually get up the nerve to act out
 such roles. So they spray gunfire into crowded swimming pools, as happened in Washington
 160 last summer; or they gun folks down on a recreation field, like the men whose stray bullets
 killed a 4-year-old girl. Too often, reality doesn't kick in until the handcuffs are slapped on,
 just as it happened to me.
 When a policeman told my stepfather and me that the guy I shot might die, I became mired
 in the weirdest illogic: It was clear that if he died, I'd be charged with murder, yet I would
 165 have denied to the end that I was a murderer.
 Why wasn't I prepared to accept the consequences of my actions or concede to being branded
 a killer if I took someone's life? Because, on some level, I was certain that the person who
 shot that guy was not really me – it was some person I'd thought I wanted to be. I'd been
 fantasizing, and fantasies don't deal with consequences.
 170 If asked, I couldn't have explained why I shot that dude. I was completely unaware of the
 forces driving me. Likewise, many of these young killers today can't tell you why they did
 what they did. They don't have a clue.
 You have only to look at juvenile assailants' faces during some of these televised arrests to see
 the utter confusion in their eyes. At those moments, they're like I was, frightened, mixed-up,
 175 suddenly facing felony charges more serious than they can comprehend.
 As people whose young are bearing the brunt of the murder and mayhem, you'd think blacks
 would have moved decisively to stop it. In the 1960s, we mobilized when white police, dogs
 and hoses were our most immediate threat. But several complex factors seem to have stumped
 our collective logic and made us second-guess ourselves. In the civil rights struggle, it was
 180 clear that there were institutions that we were taking on. And if there was some doubt about
 exactly which institutions we were up against, we at least knew that the enemy was white.
 Now we're confused and ambivalent because the faces of the triggermen are black.
 We've also been reluctant to take part in anything that could be seen as censorship. But, as
 Akbar says, "Freedoms have come to be used as a justification of anarchy. Someone has got
 185 to monitor civilized life."
 There are lots of things that we can do to stop the violence assaulting our eyes and ears. We
 can, for starters, declare war on recording companies that produce this garbage, and try to hit
 them where it hurts – in their pockets. As police groups showed when they took on Time-
 Warner over Ice-T's "Cop Killer" album, the power of embarrassment is immense.

190 One black station, KACE-FM in Los Angeles, recently decided to counter what it said is a
"disturbing trend in black music" by banning airplay of recordings that glorify drugs, sex,
abuse of women and violence. Other black stations should follow suit. We should also de-
nounce misguided rappers who spread messages of hate.
These are only first steps toward addressing a crisis in which African-American adults must
195 confront the ways we're hurting ourselves. "So many of us adults are in denial and we pay a
heavy, heavy price," says Jan Hutchinson, director of child and youth services for the D.C.
Mental Health Commission. "We have to confront these issues with these kids."
Because the hip-hop movement is so totally black (notwithstanding sales in white suburbia),
this may not be a battle that Janet Reno and others can easily join; the discussion would
200 quickly become sidetracked by issues of race.
Monitoring and ultimately reining in gangsta rap is no panacea for the problems confronting
black America. But if black America is not prepared to give our children something better
than violence and abuse to fantasize about, who will?¹

¹Source: <https://www.washingtonpost.com/archive/opinions/1993/11/14/my-rap-against-rap/do375873-557d-417a-a8a9-f3e4eb4ebb60/>, Accessed: March 18, 2022